

What Is This Room For?

One room. Twenty minutes. Three things to do about it.

Most advice about your home starts with cleaning. This starts one step earlier, with the question that decides whether the cleaning was even worth doing: **what is this room actually for?**

ONE ROOM. NOT THE HOUSE.

Do this for a single room, finish it, and stop. You can run it again next week for the next one — but a house-wide audit in one sitting is how this ends up half-done in a notebook you never open again.

1 Pick the room

1 minute

Not the worst one. **The one you're in most.** Effort spent on a room you use daily pays back daily; the spare room can wait another year, as it has been doing.

Go and stand in it. The rest of this only works from inside the room.

Pick **one**. Rooms can do two things, but only one of them wins when they disagree — and deciding which now is the entire point of this exercise.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Sleeping
And nothing else. Everything else in here is a guest. | ☐ Cooking and eating |
| ☐ Sitting with other people
Talking, eating, watching something together. | ☐ Sitting on your own
Reading, watching, recovering. |
| ☐ Working or studying | ☐ Getting in and out
Keys, shoes, coat, mail, bag. |
| ☐ Storing things
A real answer. A room that's honestly storage beats one pretending to be a study. | |

SAY IT OUT LOUD

"*This room is for ____.*" Most people have never once said what a room in their home is for, which is exactly why it drifted into being for everything.

Tick what's true **in this room**. These six cover almost everything — they're the failure modes, not a list of chores.

- ☐ **Something in here has no home.**
It gets moved, never put away, because there's nowhere to put it away to. Usually it's most of the clutter.
- ☐ **Furniture is doing a job it wasn't meant for.**
The coffee table is storage. The dining table is a desk. The chair is a laundry pile.
- ☐ **You clear it before you can use it.**
If starting the room's actual job needs a tidy-up first, the room isn't doing its job.
- ☐ **There's a pile nobody owns.**
It's been there weeks. Nobody put it there and nobody will move it.
- ☐ **One light, in the ceiling.**
The cheapest thing on this list to fix and the one that changes the room most.
- ☐ **The room has two jobs and they're losing to each other.**
Work and rest in the same space is the common one. Neither happens properly.

Not everything you ticked. **Three.** A list of three with dates gets done; a list of nine is a mood.

WHAT I'M GOING TO DO

DONE BY

WHO'S CHECKING

THE THIRD COLUMN ISN'T DECORATION

Name a real person and tell them. Ask them to check whether you *started* on time, not just whether you finished — starting is the part that goes wrong. A date nobody else knows about is a wish.

Notes

Most of this costs nothing. Moving a trash can, turning a chair, deciding where the mail goes, taking one thing off a table. The version of this advice that involves spending money is a different and much less useful guide.

If you couldn't pick a job in step 2, that's the finding. A room with no job becomes the room everything gets put in. Giving it one — even a modest one, even "storage" — is usually the highest-value decision in the house.

Renting changes less than you'd think. What a room is for, where the furniture sits, what's allowed on the surfaces and what the light is like are all yours. Paint and fittings aren't the part that decides how a place feels day to day.

Run it again when something changes. A new flatmate, a new job, a baby, a move. A room should be for whatever your life is now, and it stops being that quietly, without anyone noticing.

One room, then stop. If you're on hour two you've turned a twenty-minute decision into a project, which is the thing this guide exists to prevent.

*Nobody ever asked you what you wanted your
home to do. It's a fair question, and you're
allowed an answer.*

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